

CHINA AND TAIWAN



THE WORLD'S THIRD LARGEST COUNTRY, after Russia and Canada, China covers a vast area of eastern Asia. It has, by far, the largest population in the world and contains about 36 per cent of Asia's people. China has

a long Pacific coastline to the southeast, but also borders 14 countries inland. Closely associated with China are Taiwan, an independent island, and the two former European colonies of Hong Kong and Macao. China is ruled by a communist government, which is working to continue the country's economic boom of the 1990s.

Physical features

China's vast land area includes rugged hills, subarctic regions, deserts, and tropical plains, and is watered by many river systems. High mountains, mainly in the north and west, dominate one-third of China's land.



Huang He

Two mighty rivers flow in eastern China, the Chang Jiang and the Huang He. At 5,464 km (3,395 miles), the Huang He is known in English as the Yellow River, or "China's Sorrow", after the yellow soil left behind by its devastating floods.



Guilin Hills

China's agricultural heartland lies in the south and centre of the country. The Li river is used to irrigate land that can be intensively farmed. Here at Guilin, the river supports fishermen and their families who make a living from its rich waters. The steep Guilin Hills rise up behind the river.

Great Wall

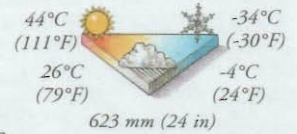
More than 2,200 years ago, about 300,000 slaves built the Great Wall of China to keep out invaders from the north. Stretching from Central Asia to the Yellow Sea, the wall's total length is 6,400 km (3,980 miles), and is the world's longest human-made structure.



Soldiers walking along the Great Wall

Climate

China has two main climates. More than half of the country is arid or semi-arid, and in



the north and west, deserts and mountains experience extreme temperature variations. The winters are bitterly cold and summers are hot and dry. The summer monsoon brings rain from the Pacific to areas nearer the sea, particularly the south and east, where conditions are wet, warm, and often humid.

